

SOUTH SAHARAN SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT ORGANISATION

IMPACT STORIES & ORGANISATIONAL ACHIEVEMENTS

Selected Evidence from 2025–2026

*Strengthening institutions. Expanding women's agency.
Improving services. Building community-led systems that last.*

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(SSDO)

Executive Overview

Over the reporting period, SSDO demonstrated a development model that works across the full pathway from evidence to implementation. The organisation generated governance data, supported state policy implementation, strengthened women-led protection systems, expanded civic participation, improved disease detection and treatment linkage, protected public infrastructure, and supported community livelihoods. The common thread is systems change: building local structures, strengthening institutional accountability, and equipping communities to sustain gains beyond a single activity.

In governance, SSDO assessed all 17 Local Government Areas of Enugu State using the Local Government Accountability Index and presented the findings to the Office of the Secretary to the State Government. It supported implementation planning for the Enugu State Youth Policy, convened stakeholders on climate-responsive public financing, trained young people in digital civic engagement, and deployed youth monitors to examine public understanding of the Nigeria Tax Act 2025.

In gender equality, the Sister Guardian Initiative continued to evolve from a community-based first-response mechanism into a wider women-led accountability system. The network spans 38 communities across Enugu and Anambra States. Six strategic partners were engaged for expansion, six Sister Guardian Champions were trained to lead replication, and Village Savings and Loan Associations were used to strengthen women's financial resilience alongside protection.

In public health, SSDO's 2026 results show scale and integration: 27,310 people screened for tuberculosis, 636 TB patients commenced treatment, 1,303 pregnant women screened for HIV and syphilis, and 16 drug-resistant TB patients supported with adherence and follow-up. Community outreach also took integrated services closer to people, while construction of a medical waste incinerator at Abakpa Health Centre moved an environmental health challenge into infrastructure implementation.

Impact at a Glance

17 LGAs

assessed through the Local Government Accountability Index; 65% recorded high performance scores.

51 youth monitors

assessed 827 traders, artisans, small business owners and private-sector professionals on the new tax law.

50+ institutions

engaged on implementation of the Enugu State Youth Policy.

27,310

people screened for tuberculosis; 636 TB patients commenced treatment.

25 VSLAs

established across SGI chapters, including 7 new VSLAs in expanded SGI communities.

6 strategic partners

engaged to support the expansion of the Sister Guardian Initiative.

50+

students trained as Menstrual Hygiene Champions.

6 WASH facilities

monitored for functionality, sustainability and accountability.

756

people registered through SSDO-supported voter registration sensitisation.

27 young people

trained in digital tools for civic engagement and advocacy.

50+ institutions

engaged on climate finance and climate-responsive public budgeting.

1,200+

people reached through World TB Day activities; another 1,200+ reached through malaria sensitisation.

38 communities

covered by the wider Sister Guardian network across Enugu and Anambra States.

150+

women and community stakeholders reached through FGM sensitisation activities.

100+

non-fiction story entries received from Nigeria and Kenya for The Cost of Justice.

1 incinerator

construction site commenced at Abakpa Health Centre to improve medical-waste management.

PART I — ORGANISATIONAL ACHIEVEMENTS

1. Governance and Public Accountability

SSDO's governance work during 2026 focused on moving accountability from broad advocacy into measurable, usable systems. The Local Government Accountability Index provided a structured way to examine transparency, public participation, fiscal accountability, service delivery and the rule of law across all 17 LGAs. SSDO took the findings to the Office of the Secretary to the State Government, placing subnational evidence directly within state decision-making platform.

- All 17 LGAs assessed; 65% recorded high performance scores.
- Fiscal accountability and documentation emerged as areas requiring attention in several LGAs.
- Local government officials and civil society stakeholders were equipped to use standardised assessment and scoring tools.
- The Index was positioned as a repeatable tool for institutional planning, reform and performance tracking.

SSDO also connected community evidence to legal reform. Its child domestic work research found that 29% of surveyed households had a child engaged in domestic service. The evidence was converted into a Memorandum submitted to the Enugu State Justice Reform Team during the review of the Child Rights Law, shifting the intervention from research publication to formal policy engagement.

2. Youth Participation: From Awareness to Practical Civic Agency

Across multiple interventions, SSDO treated young people as governance actors rather than event participants. Under the SPA II Project with ActionAid Nigeria, young people were equipped to register to vote, understand public institutions, use digital advocacy tools and generate evidence on policy implementation.

- 756 people registered through voter registration sensitisation after INEC services were brought closer to communities.
- 51 trained youth monitors assessed 827 traders, artisans, small business owners and private-sector professionals across all 17 LGAs on awareness of the Nigeria Tax Act 2025.
- 27 young people completed Digital Tools for Engagement Bootcamp 5.0, covering governance, advocacy, AI-assisted content development, website development and cybersecurity.
- Participants developed community-focused campaign plans, converting training into practical civic action.

- SSDO convened 50+ MDAs, youth-focused institutions and youth-led organisations to support implementation of the Enugu State Youth Policy and connect policy priorities with the 2027 budget cycle.

3. Climate Governance and Public Financing

SSDO's climate work focused on the implementation gap between having a policy and financing it. A two-day dialogue on climate finance and climate-responsive budgeting brought together more than 50 MDAs, youth-focused institutions and youth-led organisations to examine domestic resource mobilisation, sectoral budgeting, coordination and accountability for climate investments.

- Climate policy was connected more directly with public budgeting and financing.
- Potential domestic financing pathways were identified.
- Youth perspectives were included in public-finance discussions.
- A communiqué and actionable policy recommendations were produced.

4. Women-Led Protection and Gender-Transformative Systems

The Sister Guardian Initiative is one of SSDO's clearest examples of long-term institutional impact. What began as a pilot in Awha-Imezi in 2014 has evolved into a women-led protection and accountability network across 34 communities in Enugu and Anambra States. Sister Guardians serve as first responders, counsellors, mediators, referral partners, temporary shelter providers and advocates. Over time, the model has expanded from responding to individual cases to reshaping the community systems that enable violence and exclusion.

- The wider SGI network spans 34 communities across Enugu and Anambra States.
- 6 Sister Guardian Champions were trained to support expansion into new communities.
- 6 civil society organisations were engaged as strategic partners for structured scale-up.
- 25 VSLAs were established across SGI chapters, including 7 new VSLAs in expanded communities.
- Traditional cabinets in seven communities began opening participation to women.
- Community reforms documented include: women's land inheritance, protection for children born outside formal marriage, the abolition of a widowhood homage requirement, reduced funeral burdens, the lifting of restrictions on women tying yams, action against early/forced marriage, and community prohibition of FGM.

This evolution matters because it shifts GBV programming away from awareness-only approaches. Women are building the confidence, economic base, collective structures and negotiating power required to challenge harmful practices and participate in decision-making.

5. Economic Resilience as a Protection Strategy

SSDO's gender work recognises that economic dependence can limit a woman's ability to leave abuse, pursue justice or negotiate from a position of strength. Integrating VSLAs into the SGI model provides a community-managed financial safety net while reinforcing solidarity and mutual accountability.

- 25 VSLAs established across SGI chapters, including 7 new groups in expanded SGI communities.
- Groups adopted constitutions, elected leaders, set share values and loan conditions, established social funds and commenced savings.
- The model gives women access to affordable community credit while creating a platform for collective action and social support.

6. Public Health: Scale, Integration and Continuity of Care

SSDO's public-health contribution goes beyond stand-alone outreach. Its programme results demonstrate the linked functions required for an effective community health response: case finding, screening, treatment initiation, referral, adherence support, follow-up and integration with other services. Between 2025 – Q2 2026:

- 128,314 people were screened for tuberculosis.
- 39,767 presumptive TB cases were identified.
- 2,545 TB cases were diagnosed.
- 2,470 people diagnosed with TB were started on treatment.
- 1,303 pregnant women were screened for HIV and syphilis.
- 10 women were linked to antiretroviral treatment and antenatal services.
- 16 drug-resistant TB patients received treatment-adherence and outpatient follow-up support.
- 1,200+ community members were reached during World TB Day activities in 2026.
- 1,200+ people were reached through World Malaria Day sensitisation.

These results were reviewed through government-led NTBLCP quarterly processes, enabling implementation data to contribute to joint performance review, programme learning and improvements in case detection, treatment linkage and continuity of care.

7. Safer Health Infrastructure and Environmental Protection

At Abakpa Health Centre, SSDO moved a longstanding medical-waste problem into infrastructure implementation through the commencement of a modern incinerator project supported through the Japanese Grant Assistance for Grassroots Human Security Projects. The facility is intended to support safer medical-waste disposal for Abakpa Health Centre and surrounding public and private healthcare facilities in Enugu East LGA.

- One medical-waste incinerator construction site commenced at Abakpa Health Centre.
- The intervention addresses open burning, unsafe dumping and exposure to infectious waste.
- Government health and infrastructure institutions were engaged in implementation.
- The project is expected to strengthen infection prevention, environmental safety and regulatory compliance.

8. WASH Sustainability and Accountability

SSDO's joint monitoring of six WASH facilities focused on what happens after infrastructure is built. The exercise assessed functionality, maintenance arrangements, infrastructure condition and community-management systems, reinforcing a sustainability approach to WASH investment.

- Six water and sanitation facilities monitored.
- Operational and management risks identified for follow-up.
- Maintenance and community ownership arrangements reviewed.
- Government, technical and implementing partners reinforced shared responsibility for protecting WASH investments.

9. Menstrual Dignity and Adolescent Leadership

Through the Iwollo Period Dignity Project, SSDO supported practical menstrual-health education and reusable-pad production for secondary-school students. The intervention combined health knowledge, affordability, environmental sustainability and peer leadership.

- 50+ students trained as Menstrual Hygiene Champions.
- Students learned to produce reusable and affordable menstrual products.
- Participants were prepared to educate peers, extending the intervention beyond the original training cohort.

10. Advocacy Through Storytelling and Art

The Cost of Justice Anthology expanded SSDO's advocacy beyond conventional policy dialogue by combining lived experience, literature and visual art. More than 100 non-fiction entries were received from Nigeria and Kenya, 15 stories were selected for publication, and 15 visual artists produced 30 artworks. The anthology and exhibition created a survivor-informed platform for institutional dialogue and public education.

PART II — SELECTED IMPACT STORIES

Impact Story 1 — Lucy Odo: From Manual Labour to an Income-Generating Farm Asset

Location: Ihenyi Community, Isi-Uzo LGA, Enugu State

Lucy Odo had long depended on manual labour to cultivate rice. The process was physically demanding, time-consuming and limited the amount of land she could work. For a farmer supporting a household, the constraint also placed a ceiling on income.

SSDO response. Through a Village Savings and Loan Association, Lucy was able to save and access the finance she needed to acquire a rice planter. She used the equipment to improve her own rice production and then began hiring it out to other farmers when it was not in use.

What changed. Lucy now grows long-grain and short-grain rice and has expanded into Ogiri Okpeyi production. The rice planter has reduced her dependence on manual labour, improved farm efficiency and created an additional income stream through equipment hire. She reports being able to contribute to her children's school fees and purchase household assets, including a gas cooker that also reduced her reliance on firewood.

"I can now use the money I make from farming to take care of important things in my home. I can pay my children's school fees and buy things we need."

Why this matters. The change is larger than a single asset purchase. VSLA finance became productive capital, productive capital became diversified income, and diversified income strengthened Lucy's household contribution, confidence and economic independence.

Impact Story 2 — Chikamso Ogbuzuru: Growing a Rural Enterprise Through Savings and Skills

Location: Ihenyi Community, Isi-Uzo LGA, Enugu State

Chikamso Ogbuzuru runs a milling operation that serves farmers and other residents processing maize and farm produce. Like many small rural businesses, growth depended on the ability to reinvest in equipment and diversify income.

SSDO response. Through participation in our VSLA, Chikamso was able to save and access financial support. He added another grinding machine and improved his milling operation. He also continued practising sack farming, a method learnt we had training them on.

What changed. The additional machine increased his capacity to process produce, while sack farming gave him another practical way to grow food and supplement income. He reports being better able to care for himself and his family and has continued to expand what he does.

“I have been able to improve what I do and take better care of myself and my family.”

Why this matters. This story shows how combining access to finance with practical skills can support diversification rather than dependency on a single livelihood stream.

Impact Story 3 — Ndubuisi Okorie: Turning the Intention to Vote into the Ability to Participate

Location: Oduma Community, Aninri LGA, Enugu State

Ndubuisi Okorie wanted to vote, but like other young people in his community he had not completed voter registration. Questions about the process, access to official information and the practical burden of registration kept intention from becoming participation.

SSDO response. We had taken voter registration services and civic education to the community. We supported INEC officials to guide participants in the voter registration and civic education drive through registration and provided official information on PVC collection, voting procedures and rights under the Electoral Act.

What changed. Ndubuisi registered. Across the wider mobilisation, 756 people completed voter registration. Participants also discussed vote buying, misinformation and electoral violence, connecting registration with responsible and informed participation.

Why this matters. A concrete administrative barrier was removed, converting civic interest into actual eligibility to vote. This illustrates SSDO’s emphasis on practical access as a condition for meaningful participation.

Impact Story 4 — Oyiga Promise: Agroecology Training Put to Work

Location: Umuogili Community, Igboeze North LGA, Enugu State

Oyiga Promise farms several hectares and depends on her land for both household food and income. The challenge was not only how much she could grow, but how to manage soil, moisture and production in a way that reduced dependence on purchased inputs.

SSDO response. After our agroecology training, Promise began applying organic farming practices, producing her own manure and using mulching to protect soil and retain moisture.

What changed. She reports that the farm continues to thrive, enabling her to produce food for her household and sell the surplus. The training has become part of her everyday farming practice rather than a one-off learning event.

“I have continued to practise what I learnt because I can see the difference on my farm. I am able to grow more food, feed my family and sell what is left.”

Why this matters. The value of the intervention lies in sustained application: knowledge translated into changed farming practice, improved household food availability and an income stream from surplus production.

Impact Story 5 — Umuode: From Women Outside the Room to Women Shaping Community Justice

Location: Umuode Community, Enugu State

For years, community decision-making structures were largely male spaces. Women had no formal voice in forums dealing with land, family disputes and communal development. This was particularly limiting in cases of gender-based violence, where survivors could be uncomfortable presenting their experiences before male-only structures.

SSDO response. Through our Sister Guardian Initiative, where we work and train women in rural communities to prevent and respond to gender-based violence and harmful traditional practices, women received training in mediation, negotiation and leadership. As Sister Guardians built a track record of resolving family disputes and supporting survivors, they engaged community leaders with evidence of their contribution and the trust women placed in them.

What changed. Community leaders invited Sister Guardians into the Town Union and partnered with them to establish a Community Court that sits every Afor market day. Sustained advocacy by the Sister Guardians in Umuode has also led community leaders to prohibit female genital mutilation and introduce penalties for anyone attempting to continue the practice.

Why this matters. Umuode demonstrates the deeper institutional value of SGI. Women moved from being recipients of protection to actors inside community governance and justice structures. The same platform that responded to individual cases became a mechanism for changing norms and decision-making.

Impact Story 6 — Adani: Women Enter Community Leadership and Mobilise to Save a Survivor

Location: Adani Community, Uzo-Uwani LGA, Enugu State

Adani's Town Union had historically been male-dominated, leaving women without formal representation in the body that shaped community decisions. At the same time, survivors of intimate partner violence faced immediate protection and care gaps.

SSDO/Partner response. Sister Guardians built credibility through mediation, survivor support and sustained engagement with the Town Union. They framed women's representation as a way to strengthen community governance rather than as a rejection of tradition. In a separate emergency case, Sister Guardians mobilised their own resources when a pregnant survivor required urgent surgery after severe intimate partner violence.

What changed. Three Sister Guardian members, representing the community's three villages, were appointed to participate in Town Union leadership. In the emergency protection case, Sister Guardians pooled ₦38,000 for life-saving surgery when the survivor's husband fled.

Why this matters. The two outcomes show the model operating at different levels at once: immediate solidarity for a woman in crisis and long-term structural change in who gets to participate in community decision-making.

PART III — WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS ABOUT SSDO

1. The organisation works across the full change pathway, connecting evidence, policy, institutions and communities.
2. Its interventions build local structures that continue to function beyond individual activities and project cycles.
3. Community agency is strengthened by equipping people to participate, lead, advocate and influence decisions that affect their lives.
4. Service delivery is combined with systems strengthening to improve both immediate outcomes and long-term institutional performance.
5. The results demonstrate both scale and depth, with broad reach alongside meaningful changes in people's lives, institutions and communities.

Conclusion

The strongest story emerging from the evidence is SSDO's ability to connect community realities with institutions, policy and practical implementation. Across governance, gender equality, health, livelihoods, climate action and WASH, the organisation has built platforms through which people participate, evidence travels upward, public systems respond, and communities take greater ownership of change.